

Skullcandy Crusher ANC 2

Bass that hits hard, but does it hit right?

One of the most recognisable names in the bass-forward audio market, Skullcandy has carved a niche for itself with headphones that prioritise visceral, head-rattling low-end experiences. The latest addition to their lineup, the Crusher ANC 2, aims to refine this legacy by marrying its signature sensory bass with active noise cancellation (ANC) and modern features. Positioned as a premium yet accessible option for bass enthusiasts, these headphones promise a blend of thumping audio, robust build quality, and practicality. But do they strike the right balance, or does the bass overwhelm their other strengths? Let's dive in.

BUILD AND DESIGN

The Skullcandy Crusher ANC 2 retains the brand's penchant for understated aesthetics while leaning into a more mature design language. Gone are the flashy, neon-coloured accents of older models; instead, the headphones sport a sleek matte black finish with subtle orange highlights, including a distinctive power button. The plastic construction feels sturdy, though some reviewers noted a slight creakiness in the hinges. At 332g, these are heavier than competitors like the Sony WH-1000XM5 (250g), but the weight is well-distributed. The memory foam ear pads, wrapped in faux leather, provide a plush seal around the ears, though glasses wearers might find the clamping force a tad tight during extended sessions.

The fold-flat design and included hardshell case enhance portability, making them travel-friendly. Physical buttons dominate the controls – a

welcome choice for those averse to finicky touch gestures. The left earcup houses a bass adjustment wheel and a USB-C port, while the right side features volume, playback, and ANC mode toggles. While the tactile feedback is satisfying, the button layout can feel crowded, requiring a learning curve to avoid mispresses.

FEATURES

The Crusher ANC 2 packs a feature set tailored to bass lovers and casual listeners alike. The standout is the adjustable "Crusher Bass" slider, which lets users dial in haptic vibrations from a subtle rumble to a skull-shaking intensity. This is complemented by a five-band EQ and sound personalisation via the Skull-iQ app, which tailors audio based on a hearing test – a nod to

audiophiles seeking customization. ANC is present but falls short of class leaders like Bose or Sony. It effectively muffles low-frequency hums (think airplane engines) but struggles with higher-pitched noises like keyboard clatter. The transparency mode, dubbed "Stay Aware," amplifies ambient sounds adequately, though it lacks the natural fidelity of Apple's AirPods Max, which despite the steep price tag, are worth mentioning here because of how good they are. Other perks include Tile tracking for lost headphones, Spotify Tap integration, and multipoint Bluetooth pairing. However, the absence of high-end codecs like aptX or LDAC is a miss at this price point.

PERFORMANCE

Let's address the elephant in the room: the bass. The Crusher ANC 2 delivers seismic low-end thumps that redefine "bass-heavy."

Tracks like Kendrick Lamar's Money Trees or our standard bass test track, Uptown Funk by Bruno Mars transform into physical experiences, with haptic drivers vibrating in sync with sub-bass frequencies. However, this emphasis comes at a cost.

At higher settings, the bass drowns out mids and trebles, rendering vocals and instruments recessed. The default sound profile is V-shaped, but the app's EQ allows some correction – though purists might find the process cumbersome.

Noise cancellation is serviceable but inconsistent. While it dulls background chatter in cafes, it's no match for the Bose QC45's isolating prowess. Call quality is another weak spot: the quad-mic setup struggles in noisy environments, often letting wind or traffic bleed into conversations. On the upside, the 40mm drivers shine in genres like hip-hop, EDM, and rock, where bass takes centre stage. The

